

to find solace in it, irrespective of his prevailing mood.

At IISc, Alok Nath further broadened his knowledge about telecommunications and realised how every aspect uniquely complemented each other. It was this fascination that took him from India to Canada, where he pursued his PhD and also started another phase of his life.

Flight to Canada and international exposure

Like many middle-class Indians at that time, Alok Nath's flight to Canada was the first one he had ever taken in his life. While he was working hard to revolutionise telecommunications, calling from a foreign country was a luxury that he could not afford then. And that would also make his parents anxious at times.

"When I first landed there, I sent them a telegram but it took ten days to reach. In the meantime, my father would go to the Air India office every now and then to enquire if my flight had landed. The people there assured him that many flights had gone and come back since my flight, so I was probably already well-settled in Canada," he laughs.

Alok Nath did his PhD in 'communication with signal processing' from McGill University on a full scholarship. After 'communication with control' in IIT and 'communication with computing' in IISc, he wanted to fathom this combination as well. Alok Nath knew that it would eventually bring him to a more holistic view of telecommunications.

Surviving in Canada was no easy feat. Alok Nath had to adjust to the limited food choices and the cold climate. However, he liked the cosmopolitan culture of Montreal and saw himself living there for a long time, and hence took up learning French language.

Alok Nath's PhD thesis was supported by Canadian Institute for Telecommunication Research; he also bagged the Alexander Graham



Dr Alok Nath De with former IT Minister of Karnataka at Innovate Karnataka Launch

Bell prize in Canada for his doctoral research. His PhD mentor was a wonderful man who made the whole learning process at McGill very enjoyable for Alok Nath. "He was an immigrant himself; so he knew what challenges I was facing and he helped me navigate through them."

It was through this mentor that Alok Nath got his first break in Canada. He bagged an opportunity to work in Nortel Networks, which was then called Bell Northern Research. His first assignment had ample scope for innovation. He just needed to find the meaningful business gap. This, he credits to being curious and looking for means to go above and beyond to find a pain point he ought to fix.

But as he kept getting better at making these discoveries, he missed the excitement of implementing them and seeing them in their realised form. He knew it was time to get out of his comfort zone and soak deeply into practical implementations and field issues to grow in industry. "I told my manager that I wanted to do the dirtiest work. The most mundane things that nobody wanted to do."

In the summer of 1999, Alok Nath

made a decision that would change the trajectory of his life—leaving Canada after a decade and coming back to India. "It was one of the toughest decisions I had to make in my life," Alok Nath remarks. He was eligible for a Canadian PR. His son was three years old and had access to better education there; and he himself had a thriving career.

In his true spirit to think through and make a call, Alok Nath mulled over the situation for an entire year. He thought rationally yet infused elements of lateral thinking before taking decision. After all, he couldn't look back

and regret his decision. "I decided to come back to India. Although it seems unbelievable now, I did envision something along the lines of how India would look like in 2020, and wanted to see if I could be part of that vision coming true."

His reasoning to come back was based on two things. First, he had built a broad international perspective that expanded his mind and made him understand what makes a country developed. Second, he understood deeply what was needed to be a subject matter expert on communication with controls, computing, and signal processing elements, and build global innovative products.

He recalls, "With all that knowledge in my bag, I felt complete and thought it was the right time to come back. Many around me felt that I was taking a step backwards. But what is interesting about life is that sometimes taking an apparent step back can help you leap forward by ten steps."

Return to India and re-building from zero

Back in India, Alok Nath had uprooted his life in Canada by taking the risk of applying to only two companies. Fortunately, he received offers